

Report Part Title: Conclusion

Report Title: Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?

Report Subtitle: Political and Military Logics in the 2006 UNIFIL Enhancement

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Conclusion

This paper started with an outline of the political decision-making and military planning of the UNIFIL enhancement. It subsequently analysed UNIFIL's operational strategy and argued that this was based on a three-dimensional role for the operation, namely that of military buffer, de-escalation mechanism and booster for the local economy. Finally, it analysed the politico-military friction that manifested itself in the enhancement planning and implementation and categorised various issues into three clusters, i.e. friction bearing on information issues, organisational aspects as well as conceptual problems. On the basis of this analysis, three overall conclusions can be drawn.

First, the case-study of UNIFIL enhancement showed that the UN peacekeeping system constitutes a suitable platform for deploying European armed forces, but under two specific conditions. On the one hand, the question under which organisational flag troops are deployed was answered on a pragmatic basis. The UN framework in this case was chosen because the host nation insisted on it. The Lebanese government excluded the other options, whether NATO, ESDP or an ad hoc multinational coalition. On the other hand, the European troop contributors insisted on redesigning the organisational set-up for the operation, both in terms of expanding oversight via the SMC as well as introducing their own approach to planning operations.

Secondly, the inherent tension between the intergovernmental political decision-making process and integrated military planning that is natural to any multinational operation was replicated here, but with the addition of another layer of politico-military friction. To some extent there existed a mental gap between the UN political staff and the NATO-trained military officers from European contributors. Here the contrast was not so much between an intergovernmental versus an integrated logic, but rather between two competing views on how to manage operations. The UN approach was characterised by a much higher level of political sensitivity – with obvious implications for information management etc – and a decentralised approach to operation management. The greater political unity amongst European troop contributors as well as the preference for more robust command structures created a structural fault line in the mission early on. Both views have some legitimacy of their own right, as all the staff have to operate within the confines of risk-averse and sometimes contradictory political guidance. However, as the Security Council is rarely engaged in the details of staff work, the responsibility for political oversight shifts down to the UN administration, making politico-military friction much more of a staff issue than would otherwise be the case. Interestingly, the confrontation between both

worlds proved to be a learning experience and tensions eased over time. Individual UN staffers came to see that military planning doctrine as standardised by NATO had something to offer in terms of making planning and management processes work smoothly. At the same time, European troop contributors rediscovered UN peacekeeping ten years after leaving it and found it could be made to work better than it had in the past.

Thirdly, peacekeeping in a context such as Lebanon after the 2006 war is fraught with conceptual problems when it comes to planning doctrine. The UN's approach to operations, which is procedurally flexible but chronically under-resourced, is very light on the content of operational planning. There is no real peacekeeping doctrine spelling out how the ambitious goals set out in the mandate can be achieved. Peacekeeping thus relies on a more programmatic approach to planning operations, bringing about conditions that hopefully lead in the right direction. If such hopes prove to be idle, the operation simply goes on in time and becomes part of the scenery. NATO planning doctrine does give planners the conceptual toolkit for designing operations in content, but this conceptual toolkit is only fully applicable to missions with powerful political mandates. Traditional planning concepts such as centre of gravity and end-state remain useful as an intellectual compass, but in a peacekeeping context they lead planners to think far beyond their mandate.

In this environment, the concept of operational military strategy remains useful, but only in a limited sense. The enhanced UNIFIL is a military operation that inevitably has political effects. The most straightforward of these was that the enhanced UNIFIL made the ceasefire on 14 August 2006 possible in the first place and has contributed to maintaining it ever since. The three-dimensional strategic role outlined above does give a coherent answer to how the operation can foster intended effects. The enhanced UNIFIL in this sense does harness the use of armed forces for political ends. Yet it is equally true that such a strategy cannot achieve conflict resolution – it can only enable the sort of conditions that make renewed hostilities less likely. An operation with a limited political mandate can only achieve limited objectives. In that sense, the enhanced UNIFIL cannot be strategically decisive: it manages conflict on an interim basis, but does not make peace.